

Scraping AI Project Opportunities for Your Dev Team

Freelance Platform Projects + B2B Contracts — Python Deep Dive

Available Project:	Real-Time Object Detection for Smart Warehouse
Platform:	Freelancer.com
Description:	Client needs a YOLOv8-based system to track inventory movement on conveyor belts. ~3 month engagement.
Budget:	\$3,000 - \$5,000
Skills Required:	Python, Computer Vision, OpenCV, Edge Deployment
Posted:	1 day ago
Bids So Far:	12
Link:	https://freelancer.com/projects/...

This splits into two distinct source types with completely different scraping approaches.

Part 1: Freelance Platforms (Upwork, Freelancer.com, etc.)

These are clients posting one-off or short-term AI projects — most relevant to your team.

1A. Freelancer.com — THE EASIEST WIN

Why it's easy: Freelancer.com exposes a **public project-search JSON endpoint** that doesn't require login, cookies, or session tokens. Multiple scrapers on GitHub and Apify have confirmed this. You call their own search endpoint directly.

The endpoint pattern (reverse-engineered from public scrapers):

```
https://www.freelancer.com/api/projects/0.1/projects/active/?
  query=computer+vision+AI
  &job_details=true
  &full_description=true
  &offset=0
  &limit=20
```

What you get:

- Project title, full description, budget range, currency
- Number of current bids (crucial — fewer bids = less competition)
- Required skills/tags
- Time posted

Reliability: High. Public endpoint, no auth required, no JS rendering needed.

1B. Upwork — The Hard One

Upwork is the largest platform but intentionally hostile to scrapers:

- Heavy Cloudflare protection
- JS-rendered search results
- ToS explicitly prohibits scraping
- Account ban risk if you're logged in

Your realistic options:

Option 1: Upwork RSS (still partially alive) Some categories still expose RSS feeds. No guarantees on longevity.

```
https://www.upwork.com/ab/feed/jobs/rss?q=computer+vision+AI&sort=recency
```

Parse with Python's `feedparser`:

```
import feedparser

feed = feedparser.parse(
    "https://www.upwork.com/ab/feed/jobs/rss?q=machine+learning&sort=recency"
)
for entry in feed.entries:
    print(entry.title, entry.summary, entry.link)
```

This is fragile — Upwork can kill it anytime. But while it works, it's zero-friction.

Option 2: Apify Upwork Actor (~\$0.002/project) Apify maintains working Upwork scrapers that handle anti-bot for you. You call their API:

```
import httpx

APIFY_TOKEN = "your_token" # free tier: 5 USD credits/month
response = httpx.post(
    f"https://api.apify.com/v2/acts/devcake~upwork-jobs-scraper/runs",
    params={"token": APIFY_TOKEN},
    json={"searchQuery": "AI computer vision", "maxItems": 50}
```

```

    json=json_query : AI computer vision , maxItems : 50,
)
run_id = response.json()["data"]["id"]
# Poll for results...

```

Verdict on Upwork: Use the RSS feed while it works, fall back to Apify if you want reliability.

1C. Other Freelance Platforms

Platform	Method	Difficulty	Quality
PeoplePerHour	<code>httpx</code> + <code>selectolax</code> (mostly static)	Easy	Good for EU clients
Guru.com	Static HTML, BeautifulSoup	Easy	Decent budgets
Toptal	Some public listings, simple scrape	Easy	High-quality, large projects
Contra.com	Semi-static, newer platform	Medium	US-focused, good AI projects
Arc.dev	Public job board	Easy	Tech-focused, good rates

Part 2: B2B / Longer-Term Contracts

These are companies outsourcing AI projects, often multi-month engagements at much higher value.

2A. Hacker News "Who's Hiring" (Free, Zero Friction)

Every month on the 1st, HN posts a "Who's Hiring" thread. Companies post real AI contract/project needs. Algolia indexes every post.

```

import httpx
from datetime import datetime

def search_hn_hiring(keywords: list[str]) -> list[dict]:
    """Search Hacker News 'Who is Hiring' posts via Algolia"""
    results = []

    for keyword in keywords:
        url = "https://hn.algolia.com/api/v1/search"
        params = {
            "query": f"who is hiring {keyword}",
            "tags": "comment,story_hn_who_is_hiring",

```

```

        "hitsPerPage": 30,
    }
    resp = httpx.get(url, params=params)
    hits = resp.json().get("hits", [])

    for hit in hits:
        results.append({
            "text": hit.get("comment_text", "")[:600],
            "platform": "Hacker News Who's Hiring",
            "posted": hit.get("created_at"),
            "url": f"https://news.ycombinator.com/item?id={hit['objectID']}",
            "keyword_matched": keyword,
        })

    return results

HN_AI_KEYWORDS = [
    "machine learning engineer", "AI agent", "computer vision",
    "LLM", "fine tuning", "NLP", "data scientist", "ML platform"
]

```

These are often **contract roles and consulting engagements**, not full-time hires.

2D. Remote.io — Remote AI/Tech Projects

Fully static HTML, no bot detection, explicitly scraping-friendly attitude.

```

import httpx
from selectolax.parser import HTMLParser

def scrape_remote(query: str = "machine-learning") -> list[dict]:
    url = f"https://remote.io/remote-jobs/{query}"
    resp = httpx.get(url)
    tree = HTMLParser(resp.text)

    results = []
    for job in tree.css(".job-tile"):
        results.append({
            "title": job.css_first("h2").text(strip=True),
            "company": job.css_first(".job-tile-company").text(strip=True),
            "salary": job.css_first(".job-tile-salary").text(strip=True) if job.css_first(
            "tags": [t.text() for t in job.css(".job-tag")],
            "url": "https://remote.io" + job.css_first("a").attrs.get("href", ""),
            "platform": "Remote"
        })
    return results

```

Summary: What to Build, In Order

Day 1 — Start Here (Immediate Results)

```
pip install httpx selectolax feedparser
```

- Freelancer.com public API endpoint (no auth, works now)
- Upwork RSS feed (works now, fragile)
- HN Algolia API (always free and easy)

Week 1 — Expand

```
pip install playwright && playwright install chromium  
pip install anthropic
```

- SAM.gov API (free key, massive for B2B AI contracts)
- Wellfound + Remotive (static, easy)
- LLM formatter script

Week 2 — If You Want Upwork Properly

- Either Apify (~\$5/month for decent volume)
- Or PeoplePerHour as a replacement source

What You Should NOT Build

- A custom Upwork scraper from scratch — not worth the maintenance
- A LinkedIn scraper — too aggressive, blocks fast, legal risk
- Clutch.co scraper — that's for finding agencies, not clients posting projects

Key Insight

The bid count field on Freelancer.com is your secret weapon. A project posted 6 hours ago with 3 bids is infinitely more valuable than a project with 47 bids. Sort by `bid_count ASC` + `posted_date DESC` and you get first-mover advantage on fresh AI projects. No other public data source gives you that signal